pathogen makes its way through the country. He also wanted to enquire about the passengers who had been evacuated from Wuhan and were still housed at Army camps. The prime minister, in his monthly radio programme, would speak to several of them about their experience a few weeks later.[17]

Another big decision taken at the meeting was to suspend e-visa facilities for Chinese citizens. This was a starting point of putting restrictions on international travel. There was no doubt that this would have an impact on the markets; however, considering that very little was known about this virus and the fact that protecting our citizens was priority, this decision was made.

In order to bring them up to speed, the Group of Ministers were briefed by the MoHFW on the status of the (now) three cases in Kerala as well as the preventative measures we had begun taking.[18]

The central government suffers from peculiar strengths and weaknesses. One of its strengths is that officers from almost all parts of the country work together based on their experiences and insights attained from various postings across states. But the same quality often becomes a weakness because there is nothing to bind these officers to one another. Perhaps the only thing common between officers is that either they were in the same batch/year or that they work in the same ministries. In the words of the prime minister, the Indian administration is an ‘assembled unit’ and not an ‘organic unit’. Often what this situation does is that it doesn’t provide a common vision or mission for the officers to work on, with the officers working in the narrow silos of their departments.

The prime minister has been working to address this problem over the last seven years. He had made officers work together in various sectoral groups on issues larger than the ambit of respective departments and ministries—be it in sectoral groups or even in policy reforms like PRAGATI meetings and PM GATI SHAKTI. Due to these interventions, the GoI is now witnessing an evolving culture of team-building. With time, officers who have been working closely with the prime minister began to recognize his insistence on bureaucrats being able to work together across ministries in a ‘whole of government’ approach.

It is in this context that when the pandemic struck, while the ‘business as usual’ approach would mean that the entire pandemic-related decision-making and subsequent action would be managed by the MoHFW, but in